

Bengali, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

Companion practice lessons live alongside this book at
code/learning/human-languages/bengali/lessons/

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Preface

This is the Bengali volume of a wider project, written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Bengali letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, so you learn to read নমস্কার *and* learn what it means in the same few minutes. (A reader who already reads Bengali simply skims the “letters in this word” notes.)

Bengali (*Bāṅglā*) is an **Indo-Aryan** language — descended, like Hindi, Marathi, and Punjabi, from Sanskrit — and the mother tongue of Bengal: West Bengal in India and all of Bangladesh, some 250 million speakers, the seventh-largest language on earth. It is the language of Tagore, and the only one to have furnished the national anthem of *two* nations. One habit runs through the whole book and is worth stating up front: Bengali’s inherent vowel is **ô** (not “a”), its *s* tilts to **sh**, and its *v* collapses to **b** — so Sanskrit *namaskāra* is spoken *nômoshkar*. Learn to hear that shift and every Sanskrit-derived word becomes legible. Roots are traced to Sanskrit and, where they reach, to the wider family that also gave English its words — every form supplied in full.

Same three commitments as the other volumes: one word per lesson, gone deep; the widest *honest* web of connections; the cultural reason, not just the rule. Released under CC BY-SA 4.0.

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The Bengali script — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words.
This page gathers the system.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in vowel — and it is ô, not “a.”** ক kô, ন nô, ম mô — written left to right under a connecting top line, like Devanagari but with rounder shapes. This single fact ($a \rightarrow \hat{o}$) is why Sanskrit words sound “Bengali.”
2. **A vowel sign changes it.** কা kâ, কি ki, কী kī, কু ku, কে ke, কো ko. The *i*-signs ি/ী are written *before* the consonant but read *after* it. A *chandrabindu* ঁ nasalises the vowel.
3. **Standalone vowels have their own letters.** A vowel that *starts* a word is written in full: আ â, অ ô, ই i, উ u, এ e, ও o.

Worth flagging

- $s \rightarrow$ “sh.” The letter স (and শ, ষ) is usually pronounced “sh” — আসি is *âshi*, not *âsi*.
- **No separate *v* or *w*.** Bengali has only ব *b*, so Sanskrit *vāda* $\rightarrow$ *bād*, *Vishnu* $\rightarrow$ *Bishnu*.
- **Conjuncts.** A *hasanta* strips a consonant’s vowel so it fuses with the next: স্ + ক $\rightarrow$ স্ক, চ + ছ $\rightarrow$ চ্ছ. Many conjuncts have special shapes you learn as you meet them.

Bengali in the family

Bengali (*Bāṅglā*) is **Indo-Aryan** — from Sanskrit, like Hindi, Marathi, and Punjabi — and its script descends, with Devanagari, from the old Brahmi writing of India, which is why they share the hanging top line. It is spoken across West Bengal (India) and Bangladesh, and carries an immense literary tradition — Tagore’s poetry, the anthems of two countries. The lessons trace its Sanskrit roots and, where they reach, the wider Indo-European family that also shaped English.

Chapter 1

Greetings

The Bengali greetings — and, taught through them, how to read the Bengali script and the one sound-shift that turns every Sanskrit word into something recognisably *Bengali*. Each lesson introduces the letters its word needs. *Practice lessons: lessons/BN-C01-*.md.*

1.1 নমস্কার (*nômoshkar*) — “hello”

The letters in this word

(If you already read Bengali, skim this.) Bengali runs **left to right** under a top line, and every consonant carries a built-in vowel — but in Bengali that vowel is **ô** (an open “o”), *not* “a.” ন *nô*, ম *mô*, ক *kô*, র *rô*. A **vowel sign** changes it (া *ā*); a *hasanta* under ঞ strips the vowel so it joins the next as a conjunct: ঞ + ক → ঞ্চ.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

নমস্কার is the *same word* as the Sanskrit *namaskāra* you met in Hindi and Marathi (*namas* “a bow” + *kāra* “the making of”) — but listen to what Bengali does to it. The inherent “a” becomes **ô**, and *s* shifts to **sh**, so the written *namaskāra* is *spoken* **nômoshkar**. That one habit — *a*→*ô*, *s*→*sh* — is the fingerprint of Bengali, and once you hear it you can un-shift almost any word back to its Sanskrit cousin.

Why it’s said this way

Nômoshkar, palms together, is the everyday respectful greeting among Bengali Hindus and in formal speech generally — hello and, often,

goodbye. Bengali Muslims more often exchange *as-salāmu alaiikum* / *nāmāskār* by community; *nômoshkar* is the broad, secular-to-Hindu default. Bengali is the language of Tagore — the only tongue to have written the national anthem of *two* countries, India and Bangladesh.

1.2 ধন্যবাদ (*dhônyobād*) — “thank you”

The letters in this word

New: ধ *dhô* (breathy *d*), ব *bô*, দ *dô*, and the conjunct ন্য (ন + য *y*).
With the া sign, read ধন্যবাদ as *dhô · nyo · bā · d*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ধন্যবাদ is Sanskrit *dhanya* (“worthy”) + *vāda* (“a saying”) — the very “thank you” you learned in Hindi (*dhanyavād*), Marathi, and Punjabi. Two Bengali quirks show at once: the inherent *a*→*ô* again (*dhônyobād*), and **no separate “v”** — Bengali has only ব, so Sanskrit *vāda* is spoken *bād*. *V* becoming *b* is a Bengali signature (think of *Bishnu* for *Vishnu*).

1.3 হ্যাঁ / না (*hyā / nā*) — “yes” and “no”

The letters in this word

New: হ *hô*, the *y-phola* া that glides the sound, and the nasal mark *chandrabinḍu* ঁ (a moon-with-dot) that sends the vowel through the nose. না is simply ন + া *nā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

হ্যাঁ (*hyā*, “yes”) and না (*nā*, “no”). That “no” rides the ancient negative *na-* — the same Proto-Indo-European **ne* behind English **no**, **not**, **none**, Latin *nōn*, and Hindi *nahīn*. Bengali kept it at its shortest, bare *nā*: the family resemblance to English *no* is right on the surface.

1.4 আচ্ছা (āchchhā) — “okay / I see”

The letters in this word

New: আ — the **independent** vowel ā, the shape a word uses when it *starts* with a vowel (a built-in vowel rides a consonant; a standalone one gets its own letter). Then the doubled ছ (চ *ch* + ছ *chh*). Read আচ্ছা as ā · chchhā.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

আচ্ছা (āchchhā) is the all-purpose “okay, alright, I see, go on” — a true workhorse of spoken Bengali, from Sanskrit *acchā* (“good, clear”). It is the little word that keeps a conversation moving; a Bengali speaker will pepper speech with āchchhā... āchchhā the way an English speaker says “right... right.”

1.5 আসি (āshi) — “I’ll be going” (goodbye)

The letters in this word

New: স again — here truly “sh” — and the ি sign (*i*), which in Bengali is *written before* the consonant it follows but *read after* it. আসি = আ + সি, ā-shi.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

আসি (āshi) literally means “**I come**” — from the verb āsā (“to come,” Sanskrit root shared with Hindi ānā). Yet it is how Bengalis say *goodbye*. Never “I’m leaving” (unlucky, too final) but “I’ll come [again]” — আসি or the fuller āschhi (“I am coming”). It is the very same “promise of return” farewell you met in Tamil and Marathi: a whole culture’s optimism folded into one verb.

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Notice Bengali marks no gender on the verb — āshi is “I come” whether a man or a woman says it. That sets it apart from Marathi (*yeto* m./*yete* f.) and Hindi, and makes Bengali verbs, in this one respect, simpler than its neighbours’.

1.6 Recap

Bengali		Meaning
নমস্কার	<i>nômoshkar</i>	hello / goodbye
ধন্যবাদ	<i>dhônyobād</i>	thank you
হ্যাঁ / না	<i>hyā / nā</i>	yes / no
আচ্ছা	<i>āchchhā</i>	okay / I see
আসি	<i>āshi</i>	goodbye (“I’ll come again”)

One habit unlocks this whole chapter: Bengali’s inherent vowel is **ô**, not “a,” and its *s* leans toward **sh** while its *v* collapses to **b**. Hear those shifts and the “foreign” *nômoshkar* and *dhônyobād* snap back into the Sanskrit *namaskāra* and *dhanyavāda* you already knew. Next chapter: introducing yourself — *āmār nām...* (“my name...”) — and Bengali’s *tumi* / *āpni* (familiar / respectful “you”).

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

আমার নাম মির। (āmār nām Mira — “My name is Mira.”)
তোমার নাম কি? (tomār nām ki — “What is your name?”)

Built the same way as the greetings — each piece taken apart, its letters and root, then assembled. *Practice lessons: lessons/BN-C02-*.md.*

2.1 নাম (nām) — “name,” a word older than Europe

The letters in this word

ন (nô) + া (long ā, overriding the inherent ô) + ম (mô) → নাম (nām).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

নাম (nām) ← Sanskrit *nāman*, from Proto-Indo-European **h₃nómn*, — the *same* root as English **name**, Latin *nōmen* (English **noun**), and Greek *onoma*. Bengali *nām* and English *name* are cousins from before either language existed.

2.2 আমার (*āmār*) — “my”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

আমার (*āmār*, “my”) is the possessive of আমি (*āmi*, “I”), on the first-person stem *ām-* ← Sanskrit *asmad*. Buried in it is the same ancient *m-* of English **me**, **my**, **mine** and Latin *mē*.

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No gender here. *āmār* never changes for gender, where Hindi and Punjabi have *merā* (m.) / *merī* (f.). Bengali threw grammatical gender away entirely — one of its great simplifications, which you will meet again and again.

2.3 আমার নাম (āmār nām ...) — “my name is...,” with no “is”

আমার (my) + নাম (name) + name = “my name ...” → “my name is...” *Āmār nām Arun*.

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Bengali drops “is” in the present. There is *no verb*: Bengali sets “my name” beside “Arun” and the “is” is understood. This is the **zero copula** — for present-tense equations (X is Y), Bengali needs no “to be” (like Tamil, and unlike Hindi’s *merā nām ...hai*). A verb returns only for a *state* or *place* (Chapter 3).

2.4 তুমি / আপনি (*tumi* / *āpni*) — “you,” three ways

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

তুমি (*tumi*, familiar “you”) ← Sanskrit *tvam*, from PIE **tū* — the same root as English archaic **thou**, Latin *tū*. Bengali grades respect in **three**: তুই (*tui*, intimate), তুমি (*tumi*, familiar), আপনি (*āpni*, respectful) — like Hindi’s *tū/tum/āp*. For a first meeting, *āpni*.

2.5 কি (*ki*) — “what”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

কি (*ki*, “what”) ← the interrogative stem *ka-*, PIE **k^wo-* — the root behind English **wh-** and Latin *qu-*. Bengali’s questions nearly all begin with *k-*: *ki* (what), *ke* (who), *kôbe* (when), *kôthāy* (where), *kēmon* (how).

2.6 তোমার নাম কি? (*tomār nām ki*) — “what’s your name?”

তোমার (*tomār*, “your,” from *tumi*) + নাম (name) + কি (what) = “**your name what?**” — still *no* “*is.*” The respectful “your” is আপনার (*āpnār*, from *āpnī*): *āpnār nām ki?* — the one for a stranger.

2.7 আলাপ করে ভালো লাগলো (*ālāp kore bhālo lāglo*) — “pleased to meet you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

আলাপ করে ভালো লাগলো — “having made [your] acquaintance, it felt good.” The key word আলাপ (*ālāp*, “acquaintance, conversation”) is **Sanskrit** (*ālāpa*, *ā-* “toward” + *lap* “to speak”) — the same *ālāp* that names the slow, exploratory opening of a *rāga*, where a musician “converses” with the notes.

2.8 The whole exchange

Bengali	English
আমার নাম মির।	My name is Mira.
আপনার নাম কি?	What’s your name?
আমার নাম অরুণ।	My name is Arun.
আলাপ করে ভালো লাগলো।	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom traced: *nām* (Sanskrit *nāman*, English *name*), *āmār* (first-person *ām-*, no gender), *ki* (root *ka-*, English *what*), *ālāp* (Sanskrit “conversing”). Two Bengali habits already: the **zero copula** (no “is”), and

no grammatical gender. Next chapter: *tumi kēmon āchho?* (“how are you?”).

Chapter 3

How Are You?

After the name comes the exchange everyone actually has — and, for the first time, Bengali brings back a verb “to be”:

তুমি কেমন আছো? (*tumi kēmon āchho* — “How are you?”)
আমি ভালো আছি। ধন্যবাদ। (*āmi bhālo āchhi, dhônnobad* — “I’m well, thank you.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/BN-C03-.md.*

3.1 কেমন (*kēmon*) — “how,” another of the k-questions

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

কেমন (*kēmon*, “how, of what kind”) is from the interrogative stem *ka-*, PIE *k^w_{o-} — the root behind English **wh-** and Latin *qu-*. Bengali’s questions nearly all begin with *k-*: *ki*, *ke*, *kôbe*, *kôthāy*, *kēmon*.

3.2 তুমি কেমন আছো? — “how are you?”

The new word is আছো (*āchho*, “are you”), from the verb আছা (*āchhā*, “to be, exist, have”) + the familiar-you ending. So তুমি কেমন আছো? is “you how are?”, the verb last. Respectful: আপনি কেমন আছেন? (*āpni kēmon āchhen?*).

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Now the copula returns. Chapter 2’s zero copula covers *equations* (*āmār nām Arun*). But “how are you?” asks about a *state* — how you *exist* — and for that Bengali uses a real verb, **আছা** (*āchhā*). No verb for “my name is Arun”; a real verb for “how are you.”

3.3 আমি (*āmi*) — “I,” cousin of English *am*

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

আমি (*āmi*, “I”) descends from Sanskrit **अस्मि** (*asmi*, “I am”), from PIE *h₁es- — the “to be” root that gives English **am** and Latin *sum*. So Bengali’s word for “I” is, at the root, a form of “**am**”: “I” and “am” were once one word. Its possessive is *āmār* (“my”).

3.4 ভালো (*bhālo*) — “well,” and how to answer

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ভালো (*bhālo*, “good, well, fine”) is the everyday Bengali “good,” likely from Sanskrit **ভদ্র** (*bhadra*, “good, auspicious”). It fills the language: *bhālo lāge* (“[I] like it”), *bhālobāsā* (“love,” literally “good-dwelling”). The reply: আমি ভালো আছি (*āmi bhālo āchhi*), “I am well.”

3.5 কোনো ব্যাপার না (*kono bāpār nā*) — “no matter”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

কোনো ব্যাপার না literally “[it’s] **no matter**” — *kono* (“any”) + ব্যাপার (*bāpār*, “matter, affair”) + না (*nā*, “not”). It serves as “it’s nothing / you’re welcome.” *Bāpār* is **Sanskrit** (*vyāpāra*, “dealing”), and *nā* you met in Chapter 1 — the ancient negative, PIE *ne, behind English **no**, **not**, **none**.

3.6 The whole exchange

Bengali	English
তুমি কেমন আছো?	How are you?
আমি ভালো আছি। ধন্যবাদ।	I'm well, thank you.
কোনো ব্যাপার না।	No matter / you're welcome.

Every atom traced: *kēmon* (the *k*- questions), *āmi* (Sanskrit *asmi*, English *am*), *bhālo* (Sanskrit *bhadra*), *nā* (PIE *ne, English *no*). Next chapter: the farewells.

Chapter 4

Farewells

Chapter 1 gave you the tender আসি (*āshi*, “I’ll come [again]”). Its fuller, everyday form:

আবার দেখা হবে! (*ābār dækhā hōbe* — “We’ll meet again!”)

Practice lessons: lessons/BN-CO4-.md.*

4.1 আবার (*ābār*) — “again”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

আবার (*ābār*, “again”) is a native Indo-Aryan adverb with no tidy English cognate, but a familiar job: it turns a parting into a promise. Add it to Chapter 1’s *āshi* and you can say “we’ll meet *again*.”

4.2 দেখা হবে (*dækhā hōbe*) — “(we) will meet”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

দেখা হবে literally “[a] seeing will happen” — দেখা (*dækhā*, “seeing,” from *dækhā* “to see”) + হবে (*hōbe*, “will be/happen,” future of *hōwā* “to be/become”). Bengali says “a meeting will occur” rather than “we will meet” — an impersonal, gentle promise of reunion.

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The impersonal future. Many “we’ll...” expressions use **noun + *hōbe*** (“...will happen”): *dækhā hōbe* (“a seeing will happen”), *kôthā hōbe* (“a

talk will happen”). The event itself is the subject — no “we.”

4.3 আবার দেখা হবে (*ābār dækhā hōbe*) — “we’ll meet again”

আবার (again) + দেখা হবে (a seeing will happen) = “we’ll meet again.” It is the warm, explicit form of Chapter 1’s *āshi* — the subcontinent’s “promise of return” (Hindi *phir milenge*, Tamil *pōy varugirēṇ*), never a blunt “goodbye.”

4.4 কাল দেখা হবে (*kāl dækhā hōbe*) — “see you tomorrow”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

কাল (*kāl*) means **both “tomorrow” and “yesterday”** — the day on either side of today — from Sanskrit *kāla* (“time”), the very root behind Hindi’s *kal* and Punjabi’s *akāl* (“timeless”). The verb’s tense tells which: *kāl dækhā hōbe* (future → “tomorrow”). So the phrase is “tomorrow, a seeing will happen.”

4.5 The farewells

Bengali	English
আসি।	I’ll come [again]. (Ch.1 goodbye)
আবার দেখা হবে।	We’ll meet again.
কাল দেখা হবে।	See you tomorrow.

Roots banked: *dækhā hōbe* (the impersonal “a seeing will happen”), *kāl* (*kāla* “time,” cousin of Hindi *kal*, Punjabi *akāl*). Next chapter: the first real verbs — *āmi bānglā bôli* — and Bengali’s total lack of gender.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Until now, “to be.” Now verbs that *act* — and the gloriously simple way Bengali conjugates them:

আমি বাংলা বলি। (*āmi bānglā bôli* — “I speak Bengali.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/BN-C05-.md.*

5.1 বলা (*bôlā*) — “to speak,” your first full verb

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

বলা (*bôlā*, “to speak, say”) is a native Indo-Aryan verb (the same *bol-* as Hindi *bolnā*, Punjabi *bolṇā*). The ending া (*-ā*) is the infinitive; add ি (*-i*) to the stem for “I speak”: *bôl-* + *-i* → বলি (*bôli*).

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The verb changes for person — but *never* for gender. *āmi bôli* (I say), *tumi bôlo* (you say), *se bôle* (he/she says). There is no “he-form” vs. “she-form”: *se bôle* is “he says” and “she says.” Where Hindi and Punjabi make even “I speak” agree with the speaker’s gender (*boltā/boltī*), Bengali dropped grammatical gender entirely — one less thing to track, forever.

5.2 আমি বাংলা বলি — “I speak Bengali”

আমি (I) + বাংলা (*bānglā*, the object) + বলি (speak) — “I Bengali speak,” verb last. The name বাংলা (*bānglā*) is the language’s own word for itself

(English “Bengali” comes from it), descending from বঙ্গ (*bôngo*), the ancient name of the region — so the language is named after its land, the great delta of the Ganges.

Grammar Lens

Because Bengali verbs carry no gender, this sentence is the *same* whether a man or a woman says it — unlike Hindi. And since *-i* already means “I,” you could drop *āmi*: *bānglā bôli* is a complete “I speak Bengali.”

5.3 থাকা (*thākā*) — “to live, to stay”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

থাকা (*thākā*, “to live, stay, remain”) is from Sanskrit স্থা (*sthā*, “to stand, stay”), the PIE root **steh₂-* that also gives English **stand**, **stay**, **state** and Latin *stāre*. “I live in Kolkata” is আমি কলকাতায় থাকি (*āmi Kolkātāy thāki*) — stem + the *-i* “I,” no gender.

Grammar Lens

“**In**” comes after the noun. কলকাতায় (*Kolkātāy*) = *Kolkata* + *-y* (“in, at”), on the noun’s *end*. Bengali uses **postpositions** where English uses prepositions.

5.4 কাজ করা (*kāj kôrā*) — “to work”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

করা (*kôrā*, “to do, make”) is from Sanskrit *kr* (“to do”), PIE **k^wer-* — the root of Chapter 1’s *nômoshkar* (*namas* + *kāra*, “the *making* of a bow”) and of *karma*. And কাজ (*kāj*, “work”) is itself from Sanskrit *kārya* (also from *kr*). Bengali builds compounds as **noun** + করা: কাজ করা (*kāj kôrā*, “work-do” = “to work”). So *āmi kāj kôri* = “I work.”

5.5 Sentences about yourself

Bengali	English
আমি বাংলা বলি।	I speak Bengali.
আমি কলকাতায় থাকি।	I live in Kolkata.
আমি কাজ করি।	I work.

Three verbs, one gender-free engine: the *-i* “I” ending, the verb always last, and **never** a change for gender. Roots banked: *bôlā* (native), *thākā* (*sthā* → English *stand/stay*), *kôrā* (*kr* — root of *nômoshkar*; *kāj* “work” ← *kārya*), and *bānglā* (*bôngo*, the Ganges delta). From here, Bengali’s sentences only grow.